You rush a miracle man, you get a rotten miracle.

The Princess Bride, 1987 film

This is a harmful approach. In some rare situations, a team is available in India, which is fully imbued with a problem, has the right understanding, has the right human networks in the country, has learned how to work with each other, and can move at high speed in executing a reform. Even under these conditions, drafting laws and building state capacity takes a long time.

In most situations, there is a starvation of intellectual capacity in the country. We lack data, knowledge, experts and teams that know how to work with each other. There is thus a slow process of understanding problems, designing solutions, going up from individuals to teams with esprit de corps, and implementing reforms.

The cult of speed yields failure in both cases. Even when the best teams are assembled, if the work which requires two years is compressed into a few months, this will be done badly. With weak teams, the pressure of solving a problem in a few months surely yields failure.

There is a pipeline in the policy reform process: data to research to policy proposals to consensus to government decisions to policy implementation. It is not possible to short-circuit this process. Some fields are at a weaker stage, where the basics of data and research are not in place. In these fields, the only horizons over which meaningful policy reform can be achieved are a long time horizon.

The cult of speed is ultimately derived from management failure in government. We are faring poorly on establishing institutions which contain harmonious teams that impound information and expertise; we are unable to make long-term plans and stay focused on them. We suffer from a strong pace of personnel changes, which prevent the development of knowledge and rapport within policy teams. We suffer from three-page notes of individual reform measures, typically written by interested parties, which lack strategic thinking. We fluctuate from one topic to another, based on the crises that engulf us each day. When a government flits from one issue to the next based on the news cycle, there is no strategy.